

**Unit 1, Option B,
Topic B6: The
Thirty Years War
and its Impact
on Continental
Europe, 1618-60**

The focus of this topic is on Thirty Years War and its political, social and economic effects on the people and states of continental Europe. This excludes its impact on Britain. Since the focus of Unit 1 is on broad themes, questions will not be set which focus exclusively on depth of knowledge, for example about one particular individual or event, other than those which are specifically listed in the content bullet points. Students will, however, be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the content bullet points by the selection and deployment of relevant information as exemplification.

The content bullet points should not each be considered in complete isolation from one another and students should develop an appreciation of links between them. For example, in explaining the length of the conflict, students will draw from bullet points 2 and 3. Collectively, the bullet points offer a framework for understanding of the war and its causes, outcome and significance.

The first bullet point focuses on the origins and outbreak of the war. Students should be aware of the religious tensions that preceded the outbreak of fighting in 1618 and of the role and nature of Habsburg power in Germany, Bohemia and Austria. They can exemplify this by reference to religious divisions in the Holy Roman Empire, the structure of the empire and the increasingly militant Catholicism demonstrated by the Habsburgs and their allies, but they are not required to have knowledge of events before 1618. They should have knowledge of the Bohemian crisis that began in 1618 and the offer of the Bohemian crown to Frederick, Elector Palatine in 1619.

The second bullet point relates to the first phase of the war, from Frederick's acceptance of the Bohemian crown to the intervention of Gustavus Adolphus in June 1630. Students should understand the weakness of the protestant union and can refer to Frederick's expulsion from Bohemia and loss of his inherited lands in the Palatinate to demonstrate its effects. They should understand why neither England nor the Netherlands could intervene effectively and why Danish intervention failed to prevent Wallenstein from extending Habsburg power to the shores of the Baltic. They should understand how this brought about Swedish intervention and the aims and ambitions that motivated Gustavus Adolphus.